

Chicago Tribune



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TUESDAY, MAY 13, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Boy ‘the protector of his mother’

Prosecutors open case against alleged killer of 11-year-old

By Madeline Buckley and Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

The text messages came at a relentless pace for months.

Laterria Smith was bombarded with scores of frightening missives from Crosetti Brand, the on-and-off boyfriend she was trying to cut ties with, she told a jury Monday. He texted “yo” over and over when she didn’t respond. He called her repeatedly, sometimes masking his number.

Occasionally, she said, he would switch gears and apologize. Then, he would threaten to kill her.

Brand, 39, tried to make good on his promise on March 13, 2024, prosecutors allege, barging into her Edgewater apartment and stabbing her and her 11-year-old son Jayden Perkins. The words on his lips were chilling: “He told me, if he couldn’t have me, nobody would,” Smith said.

But her son charged at her attacker, she said. Jayden screamed: “No,” trying to pull the much larger adult man off his mother.

Jayden died from his stab wound and Smith, pregnant at the time, was seriously injured.

Just a little over a year after the attack, Brand is standing trial on felony charges of murder, attempted murder,

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US, China lower tariffs for 90 days

DC cuts tax to 30%; Beijing trims tax to 10%; markets rally

By Jamey Keaten, David McHugh, Elaine Kurtenbach and Ken Moritsugu
Associated Press

GENEVA — The United States and China agreed Monday to slash their massive recent tariffs, restarting stalled trade between the world’s two biggest economies and setting off a rally in global financial markets.

Futures for the S&P 500 jumped 3.3% — the index at the heart of many 401(k) accounts is back above where it was on April 2, when President Donald Trump announced stiff world-wide tariffs that ignited worries about a potentially self-inflicted recession — and the Dow Jones Industrial Average rose more than 1,100 points. The Nasdaq composite climbed 4.3%. Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index surged nearly 3%, and benchmarks in Germany and France were both up 0.7%.

But the de-escalation in Trump’s trade wars did nothing to resolve underlying differences between Beijing and Washington.

The deal lasts 90 days, creating time for U.S. and Chinese negotiators to reach a more substantive agreement. But the pause also leaves tariffs higher than before Trump

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People walk the halls at the state Capitol in Springfield on Feb. 1. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Spending plan leaves little wiggle room

Tight fiscal picture, federal funding uncertainty complicate state budget talks

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — With less than three weeks until the Illinois legislature’s scheduled adjournment, lobbyists, nonprofits, activists and others are ramping up efforts to get a piece of the state’s multibillion-dollar budget for everything from after-school funding to housing for people leaving prison.

But Gov. JB Pritzker’s February spending plan leaves little wiggle room for lawmakers. In addition to a projected budget shortfall

estimated at close to \$1 billion, legislators have to come to terms with President Donald Trump’s tariffs that have rattled the economy, while his newly formed Department of Government Efficiency has vowed to slash significant federal funding across the board. Pritzker’s adversarial relationship with the Republican president could make Illinois a target for any of those federal cutbacks.

At a luncheon event last week, House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch discussed how the uncertainty could force lawmakers

back to Springfield this summer to make adjustments to the budget that goes into effect July 1.

“We’re going to pass the budget here in the next couple of weeks with the information we know. There’s a lot of things we don’t know,” the Hillside Democrat said. “The only thing we can do is be committed to a process that’s going to have everyone at the table and continue to say we’re not going to spend more than we’re bringing in.”

The state’s fiscal picture brightened somewhat with an April report from the legislature’s

Commission on Government Forecasting and Accountability that projected state revenue growth would be \$266 million higher than the March estimate. The commission’s figure, however, still falls \$471 million short of the \$55 billion in state revenues Pritzker used in his February budget proposal.

Last year, legislators had to pass a \$750 million tax hike package to cover a deficit pegged at about \$900 million. It took the House three tries and a series of

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ROBERT LOERZEL/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

RETURN FLIGHT

A female piping plover known as Searocket walks near Lake Michigan at Montrose Beach on Monday.
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Underdog status suits Kelly

Despite having more years in public office than other candidates in the Democratic primary race to replace retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin, U.S. Rep. Robin Kelly on Monday embraced her underdog status.
Chicagoland, Page 3

Trump heads to Middle East

On his trip this week to the Middle East, President Donald Trump will visit Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates, although his most pressing regional challenges concern two other countries: Israel and Iran.
Nation & World

Property tax bills likely to be delayed

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Tax bills for Cook County property owners are likely to be delayed after a data snafu at the Cook County assessor’s office held up a key step in the property tax process, setting off another round of finger-pointing among property tax leaders.

The delay is the latest setback for county officials. Aside from tax bill delays during the pandemic, tax officials have been at odds or openly feuding for several years over the accuracy of assessments, the expense of tech upgrades and plain politics.

Assessor Fritz Kaegi’s office is blaming Tyler Technologies, the contractor in charge of updating the data systems across the county’s property tax offices, for the delay. Other property tax officials, however, say Kaegi is at fault for failing to prioritize this issue and missing a foundational step in the tax process.

“While we wish the Assessor had brought this issue to the

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TODAY’S WEATHER



High 76 Low 57

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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